

DECODED EXPLAINED

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In Census, Caste Category Must Not Be Open-Ended

In Census, caste category must not be open-ended



The experience of the Socio-Economic and Caste Census, 2011 is a cautionary example. The use of an open column resulted in over 46 lakh different caste entries, largely due to spelling variations, sub-castes and inconsistent reporting

RECENT NEWS reports indicate that the rehearsal for the second phase of Census 2027 includes an "open column" for recording caste. While the government has clarified that the final methodology will be decided after evaluating feedback from the test exercise, experience from previous surveys suggests that relying solely on an open-text response without a standardised coding framework can undermine the objective of caste enumeration.

The experience of the Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC), 2011 is a cautionary example. The use of an open column resulted in over 46 lakh different caste entries, largely due to spelling variations, regional names, sub-castes, synonyms, and inconsistent reporting. As a result, the data could not be effectively classified or officially released for policy purposes. This stands in contrast to earlier and more structured exercises. The 1931 Census recorded approximately 4,147 castes, while the Anthropological Survey of India identified around 6,325 castes in 1951. More recently, states that adopted a standardised coding methodology have shown that accurate enumeration is feasible and reliable.

The Bihar Caste Survey (2023) identified 209 castes, including 112 in the recognised state list of Extremely Backward Classes, 30 under OBCs, 22 SCs, 32 STs, seven Upper Castes, and two Other Related Castes. The Telangana Socio-Economic, Educational, Employment, Political and Caste Survey, 2024 identified 242 castes: 133 Backward Classes, 59 Scheduled Castes, 32 Scheduled Tribes, and 18 Other Castes. Both relied on officially recognised caste lists and assigned standardised codes to each caste, ensuring consistency and minimising duplication.

As the Union government finalises the methodology for Census 2027, it must constitute an expert committee to determine the authoritative source for caste coding. The committee should examine what the framework should be based on: State-wise lists of SCs, STs, and OBCs; the central list of OBCs maintained by the National Commission for Backward Classes; the caste database maintained by the Anthropological Survey of India; or a harmonised national master list integrating these while accommodating state-specific variations. The identification of Upper Castes also requires a clear framework. Since EWS certificates are issued to persons belonging to communities not included in the SC, ST, or OBC categories, the government already has an administrative basis for identifying such communities. This can be refined and incorporated into the Census coding methodology. An open column should remain available only to capture genuine omissions, new caste names, or regional variations.

A well-designed caste census is not merely about counting communities; it is about generating accurate data to identify deprivation, measure inequality, and formulate targeted policies for communities that remain socially and educationally backward. The success of Census 2027 will depend on the government's ability to classify every recorded caste through a transparent, standardised, and nationally accepted coding system.

The writer is national president, All India OBC Students Association

In Census, Caste Category Must Not Be Open-Ended

Census is a Union Subject under the Constitution

Historical Context

1881-1931: Caste data was regularly collected.

Post-1951: Independent India's censuses excluded caste enumeration, except for Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs).

1931: The last complete caste enumeration was conducted.

SECC 2011: Data on caste was collected, but the findings were not published due to concerns about data quality and consistency.

Caste Surveys vs. Caste Census

Survey: Conducted for a limited time and specific region.

Census: A statutory process under the Constitution, implemented nationwide.

In Census, Caste Category Must Not Be Open-Ended

Anthropological Survey of India

It is a **government-funded organization** that conducts anthropological research and studies on the diverse cultures of India.

It is the **only research organization** to pursue anthropological research in the Central Government under the Ministry of Culture.

Headquarters: Kolkata, West Bengal.

It was established in 1945 under the leadership of **Dr. S.C. Roy, a renowned anthropologist.**

AnSI was initially set up to study the tribes and castes of India and their way of life.

History

The Anthropological Survey of India was established on 1st December, 1945 in Kolkata. It originated as a Zoological and Anthropological Section under the Geological Survey of India in 1902.

In 1916, it became the Anthropological Section of the Zoological Survey of India. Finally in 1945, it was accorded the status of an independent organization under the **Department of Culture.**

In Census, Caste Category Must Not Be Open-Ended

- **The Trigger**
 - Reports indicate the rehearsal for Census 2027's second phase includes an "open column" for recording caste; government says the final methodology will be decided after evaluating test-exercise feedback
- **The SECC 2011 Cautionary Example**
 - The open-column approach in the Socio-Economic and Caste Census (SECC) 2011 produced over 46 lakh different caste entries due to spelling variations, regional names and inconsistent reporting data too messy to officially release
- **Structured State Exercises That Worked**
 - Bihar's Caste Survey (2023) identified 209 castes; Telangana's caste survey (2024) identified 242 castes both used officially recognised caste lists with standardised codes
- **The Proposed Fix**
 - The Union government should constitute an expert committee to determine an authoritative caste-coding source, drawing on State-wise lists, the central OBC list, and the Anthropological Survey of India's caste database
- **The Larger Point**
 - A well-designed caste census is about generating accurate data to identify deprivation and formulate targeted policies success depends on a transparent, standardised, nationally accepted coding system

India-U.S. Defence Tech Ties — Big Ambitions, Little Delivery

India-U.S. defence tech ties — big ambitions, little delivery

India-United States defence cooperation has acquired an unenviable reputation in strategic circles for generating ambitious political announcements that fail to translate into industrial outcomes. Over the past two decades, successive administrations in New Delhi and Washington have unveiled defence technology partnerships and industrial collaborations promising to transform bilateral military ties, only for them to become bogged down in protracted negotiations, export-control restrictions, technology-transfer disputes and differing commercial expectations.

The irony is that the relationship itself has expanded considerably. Since 2002, India has acquired over \$22 billion worth of U.S. defence equipment, including Apache and Chinook helicopters, C-17 and C-130J transport aircraft, P-8I maritime patrol aircraft, and M777 howitzers. While the US has become a major defence supplier, meaningful co-production and technology transfer remain elusive.

The case of the GE engine

The recent impasse over General Electric's (GE) F414 fighter engine, once hailed as the centrepiece of bilateral defence cooperation, is merely the latest – and arguably the most significant – illustration of the gap between political declarations and industrial outcomes. The estimated cost of each F414 engine has reportedly nearly tripled, rising from around ₹70 crore-80 crore to over ₹200 crore. GE has also sought an Indian investment of around \$800 million (₹7,576 crore) to establish a dedicated production line.

Disagreements over technology transfer, intellectual property and export controls have further complicated negotiations. Hindustan Aeronautics Limited is negotiating procurement and licensed manufacture of the F414 for the Tejas Mk-II, while the Defence Research and Development Organisation and Aeronautical Development Agency are separately engaging GE over the same engine for the proposed **Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA)** and the Indian Navy's Twin-Engine Deck-Based Fighter. The result is a web of interlinked negotiations proving difficult to resolve.

The F414 programme was unveiled during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 2023 Washington



Rahul Bedi

Defence reporter and analyst based in New Delhi and Chandigarh

visit as the flagship achievement of the Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technologies (iCET), intended to symbolise a shift from a buyer-seller relationship towards genuine defence-industrial collaboration. Instead, it has become another illustration of the enduring gap between political ambition and industrial reality. Nor is this an isolated instance.

Vision to stagnation

The first serious attempt to institutionalise defence cooperation came in 2012 with the Defence Technology and Trade Initiative (DTTI). Conceived to promote co-development and co-production, it generated years of meetings but delivered no significant military capability before fading into irrelevance.

Its successor, iCET (2022), expanded the agenda to semiconductors, artificial intelligence, quantum technologies, telecommunications, space, biotechnology, drones and resilient supply chains. Among its principal defence initiatives was the GE F414 programme, whose unresolved negotiations have become emblematic of the wider difficulty in translating political ambition into industrial outcomes.

The **India-United States Defence Acceleration Ecosystem (INDUS-X)**, launched in 2023 to link defence start-ups, academia and industry, likewise generated enthusiasm but has yet to produce noteworthy co-development outcomes. Other prospective collaborations have fared little better. Discussions on co-producing the Javelin anti-tank guided missile have remained unresolved for more than a decade, while the proposed collaboration on the General Dynamics Stryker infantry combat vehicle has suffered a similar fate. Both now appear increasingly likely to be shelved quietly.

Even India's 2024 acquisition of 31 MQ-9B SkyGuardian and SeaGuardian remotely piloted aircraft from General Atomics through the U.S. government's Foreign Military Sales route for around \$3.5 billion has resembled a purchase rather than the industrial collaboration originally envisaged. Its promised package – including local assembly, partial manufacture and a domestic maintenance, repair and overhaul ecosystem – has yet to materialise.

Taken together, these outcomes reveal a pattern that is difficult to ignore. Successive

India-U.S. defence initiatives have been heralded as “historic”, “transformational” or “game-changing”, yet implementation has repeatedly fallen well short of the rhetoric.

The technology transfer divide

At the heart of this disconnect lie fundamentally different philosophies underpinning the two countries' defence sectors. India views defence partnerships as a means of acquiring advanced technologies, strengthening indigenous manufacturing and reducing dependence on imported matériel.

The U.S., by contrast, regards advanced defence technologies as strategic assets governed by stringent export-control regulations, particularly the **International Traffic in Arms Regulations (ITAR)**, under which the release of technical data and manufacturing know-how remains subordinate to broader security considerations.

The unresolved F414 negotiations illustrate this divide. India has sought manufacturing expertise and intellectual property to build long-term domestic capability, while the U.S. remains constrained by export-control regimes regardless of Washington's broader strategic objectives. The consequence is a defence relationship that has matured as a procurement partnership but far less as a mechanism for transferring capability and strengthening India's *atmanirbharta*.

Despite the undeniable expansion of India-U.S. strategic ties – marked by increasingly sophisticated military exercises, logistics agreements and enhanced interoperability – the industrial dimension of the relationship has yet to keep pace. The alphabet soup of DTTI, iCET and INDUS-X has largely disappointed, leaving officials in both countries looking to the proposed Reciprocal Defence Procurement Agreement (RDPA) as the next test of industrial cooperation.

The U.S. believes that the RDPA could reshape bilateral defence trade by granting reciprocal access to each other's procurement markets. Yet, that reciprocity could expose India's still-nascent defence manufacturers to direct competition with America's larger, wealthier and technologically more advanced defence giants. Whether this creates genuine balance or simply institutionalises unequal competition is another matter altogether.

Meaningful defence technology collaboration continues to elude the United States and India

India-U.S. Defence Tech Ties — Big Ambitions, Little Delivery

- **General Security Of Military Information Agreement**

- GSOMIA allows militaries to share the intelligence gathered by them.
- Signed by India in **2002**.
- The GSOMIA was limited to public companies of both the countries but signing ISA allowed both public and private companies.
- An extension to the GSOMIA, the **Industrial Security Annex (ISA)**, was signed at the 2+2 dialogue in 2019. **ISA provides a framework for exchange and protection of classified military information between the USA and Indian defence industries.**

DTTI (Defence Technology and Trade Initiative) – 2012

Promotes co-development and co-production of defence technologies.

Intended to move beyond simple arms sales.

Encourages collaboration between defence industries.

- **Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement**

- **LEMOA** allows both countries to have access to each other's designated military facilities for refueling and replenishment.
- Signed by India in **2016**.
- **The LEMOA does not make the provision of logistic support binding on either country and requires individual clearance for each request**

India-U.S. Defence Tech Ties — Big Ambitions, Little Delivery

- **Major Defence Partner (MDP) Status – 2016**
 - India was designated a Major Defence Partner by the United States.
 - Facilitates access to advanced defence technology and high-end military equipment.
 - Recognises India's strategic importance.
- **Communications and Information Security Memorandum of Agreement**
 - Valid for 10 years, **COMCASA** aims to provide a legal framework for the transfer of highly sensitive communication security equipment from the USA to India that will streamline and facilitate interoperability between their armed forces.
 - Signed by India in **2018**.
- **2+2 Ministerial Dialogue – 2018**
 - Annual dialogue involving Defence and Foreign Ministers of both countries.
 - Reviews strategic, defence and security cooperation.
 - Highest institutional defence dialogue.

India-U.S. Defence Tech Ties — Big Ambitions, Little Delivery

What is BECA?

The Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement largely pertains to geospatial intelligence, and sharing information on maps and satellite images for defence.

Signed in 2020

INDUS-X: The launch of the India-US Defense Acceleration Ecosystem (INDUS-X) in June 2023, fostered defense innovation and industrial cooperation.

Security of Supply Arrangement (SOSA)

Promote national defence: Governments to secure the mutual timely provision of defence-related goods and services during peacetime, emergency, and armed conflict.

Meet national security needs: It would allow both countries to request each other for priority delivery of certain defence items.

India is the 18th SOSA partner of the US. It is legally non-binding.

India-U.S. Defence Tech Ties : Big Ambitions, Little Delivery

The Reciprocal Defence Procurement Agreement (RDPA) is a **bilateral pact proposed between the US and India** to ease defense trade, remove regulatory barriers like the Buy American Act, and streamline technology transfers.

Key Objectives

Market Access: Gives Indian defense firms easier access to the \$850 billion US procurement market.

Rationalization & Interoperability: Standardizes procurement procedures, allowing both nations to integrate supply chains and easily purchase defense goods during critical situations.

Friendshoring: Promotes defense trade and industrial resilience between allied democracies

Reciprocal Defence Procurement Agreement (RDPA) is a **legally binding international treaty.**

India-U.S. Defence Tech Ties : Big Ambitions, Little Delivery

- **The Core Critique**

- India-US defence cooperation has generated ambitious political announcements that repeatedly fail to translate into industrial outcomes, despite the relationship expanding considerably in dollar terms

- **The GE F414 Engine Impasse**

- Once hailed as the centrepiece of cooperation, the F414 engine deal remains unresolved; estimated engine cost has nearly tripled to over Rs 200 crore, with GE seeking an \$800 million Indian investment for a dedicated production line

- **A Pattern of Stalled Initiatives**

- The Defence Technology and Trade Initiative (2012) faded into irrelevance; iCET's flagship F414 programme has stalled; INDUS-X and talks on Javelin and Stryker co-production have similarly failed to deliver

- **The Technology Transfer Divide**

- India seeks technology and manufacturing know-how for indigenous capability; the US treats such technologies as strategic assets restricted under regulations , creating a structural mismatch

- **The Road Ahead**

- Officials are looking to the proposed Reciprocal Defence Procurement Agreement (RDPA) as the next test, though critics worry it could expose India's nascent defence manufacturers to direct competition with larger US firms

India-U.S. Defence Tech Ties : Big Ambitions, Little Delivery

1961	<u>HF-24 Marut uses imported British Orpheus engines due to lack of a suitable indigenous engine.</u>
1989	<u>DRDO launches the Kaveri engine project.</u>
2000s	<u>Kaveri fails to meet thrust and reliability requirements for Tejas.</u>
2010s	<u>Tejas Mk-1 enters service with imported GE F404 engines.</u>
2023	<u>India-US announce HAL-GE F414 manufacturing and technology transfer in India.</u>
2024-26	<u>Negotiation delays, pricing concerns, and supply issues affect Tejas Mk-2 and AMCA timelines.</u>

India's Biggest Parking Problem Is That It's Free



PUSHPA PATHAK

THE SUPREME Court's June 19 judgment on the fundamental right to walk highlighted "the violation of the right to walk on demarcated footpaths". The ruling draws our attention to another serious violation of footpaths and roadsides: Using them as free parking spaces for motorised vehicles.

Nowhere is this more contested than in residential and mixed land-use neighbourhoods. On June 18, a 77-year-old died after being pushed to the ground during a heated argument over open-space parking with his 30-year-old neighbour in Noida. On January 13, an argument over parking in Jashoda Colony, Vadodara resulted in the brutal killing

of a visitor. These stories of violent disputes force us to stop and wonder: How is the challenge to be handled? What if cities legalised parking on public land for a price? Would it reduce conflicts?

The underlying cause is the growth in car ownership in India's urban areas, particularly in the metropolises, and shrinking of free parking spaces. It also comes from a strong sense of entitlement to the public space in front of one's house.

A few states and cities have adopted policy frameworks that specifically address residential parking. For instance, Comprehensive Policy on Traffic, Road Safety, Encroachment and Cattle Menace for Ahmedabad City (2026) stipulates that no development permission shall be granted without a pre-building use parking compliance. The Odisha Comprehensive State

Parking Policy (2026) includes provisions for residential parking permits. Maharashtra's "No Parking, No Car" policy (2025) requires residents of large urban centres to present proof of an authorised parking space for registration of new vehicles. Bengaluru's Management and Maintenance of Parking Rules, 2018, later integrated into Parking Policy 2.0 (2021), mandates paid on-street parking across the city, including in front of your house, and proof of parking for new vehicle registrations. The Delhi Maintenance and

Paid parking systems can help reclaim footpaths, reduce congestion, improve emergency access, and create disincentives for families to own multiple cars

Management of Parking Rules, 2017 proposed a system for on-street paid parking in residential areas that included double the normal parking charge for spillover from still parking. It was supported by the Supreme Court but full citywide enforcement is far from being achieved. However, the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988 and the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989 do not require proof of an ensured parking space as a precondition for registering a new car anywhere in India.

Expert opinion is clearly against free parking on public land. Proponents of David Harvey's "Right to the City" approach argue that free or subsidised parking on roads represents elite capture of valuable public land by a car-owning minority and that it creates severe inequality. Donald Shoup, urban planning professor at UCLA, in his book *Parking and the City*, argues that free over-

supply of parking increases excessive car use, congestion and housing costs, and that appropriately priced parking can lead to more efficient, equitable, and sustainable cities.

Indian cities facing rapid motorisation and limited street space have no option but to move toward regulated, priced, and permit-based residential parking. Paid parking systems can help reclaim footpaths, reduce congestion, improve emergency access, and create disincentives for families to own multiple cars. Additionally, parking fees can provide a stable source of revenue for urban local bodies, which can be reinvested in improving public goods such as transport, pedestrian infrastructure, green areas and neighbourhood amenities.

The writer is a senior fellow at the Centre for Policy Research, New Delhi. Views are personal

India's Biggest Parking Problem Is That It's Free

- **The Supreme Court Trigger**

- The SC's June 19 judgment on the fundamental right to walk highlighted "the violation of the right to walk on demarcated footpaths", drawing attention to footpaths being used as free parking for vehicles

- **The Underlying Cause**

- Rising car ownership combined with shrinking free parking space has fuelled a sense of entitlement to park in front of one's house, sometimes escalating to violent disputes

- **State/City Responses So Far**

- Ahmedabad's Comprehensive Policy (2026), Maharashtra's "No Parking, No Car" policy (2025), and Bengaluru's Parking Policy 2.0 have introduced proof-of-parking and paid on-street parking rules, though enforcement remains inconsistent

- **The Free Parking Debate**

- Urban economist Donald Shoup argues free/subsidised parking represents elite capture of public land, worsening inequality and congestion, versus "Right to the City" advocates who see paid parking as disadvantaging the poor

- **The Way Forward**

- Experts broadly favour regulated, priced, permit-based residential parking reclaiming footpaths, reducing congestion, improving emergency access, and generating stable municipal revenue

India's Biggest Parking Problem Is That It's Free

Right to the City

Origin: The concept was first developed by French sociologist Henri Lefebvre in his 1968 book *Le Droit à la Ville* (The Right to the City).

Meaning: It is the collective right of all urban residents not just property owners to access, use, participate in, and shape the city and enjoy the benefits of urban life without exclusion or discrimination.

Global Recognition: The idea gained prominence in the 1990s through geography and urban planning and was later reflected in the New Urban Agenda (Habitat III, 2016) and SDG 11 – Sustainable Cities and Communities.

India's Biggest Parking Problem Is That It's Free

Consider the following statements:

1. 'Right to the City' is an agreed human right and the UN-Habitat monitors the commitments made by each country in this regard.
2. 'Right to the City' gives every occupant of the city the right to reclaim public spaces and public participation in the city.
3. 'Right to the City' means that the State cannot deny any public service or facility to the unauthorized colonies in the city.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

This question was previously asked in
UPSC Civil Services Exam...

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1. 1 only

2. 3 only

3. 1 and 2 only

4. 2 and 3 only

Steady in Turbulence: India Must Build Partnerships in This Age of Global Turmoil

Steady in turbulence

India must build partnerships in this age of global turmoil

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent visits to Australia and New Zealand marked yet another step in India's efforts to consolidate partnerships across the Indo-Pacific. India's relations with both countries have traditionally been largely economic and people-centric, but the visits underscored an increased emphasis on strategic aspects, a fresh turn. Geopolitical competition, manifested in supply-chain disruptions and the realignment of global economic networks, is keeping the world on tenterhooks, and India has to manage the uncertainties and volatility well to be able to protect its vital interests. The visits reflected New Delhi's attempt to strengthen the southern arc of the Indo-Pacific under its Act East Policy, MAHASAGAR (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions) vision, and commitment to a free, open and inclusive Indo-Pacific. India and Australia adopted a new Joint Declaration on Defence and Security Cooperation, significantly upgrading the existing security framework. They agreed to enhance interoperability between their armed forces, expand military exercises, establish an Annual Defence Ministers' Dialogue, and strengthen cooperation in cybersecurity, maritime security and emerging technologies. An India-Australia Maritime Security Collaboration Roadmap was unveiled to deepen information sharing and operational coordination in the Indo-Pacific. An immediate and consequential outcome was Australia's decision to allow uranium exports for India's civilian nuclear programme, removing a lingering obstacle in ties and boosting India's clean-energy ambitions. Both countries will also find new avenues of cooperation on critical minerals, a specific field of global uncertainty.

India-New Zealand relations are now a formal strategic partnership, with a road map for cooperation over the next four years. Key agreements announced by the countries include maritime cooperation in the Indo-Pacific and mutual logistics support between the Indian Navy and the New Zealand Defence Force. Building upon the recently concluded India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement, both sides agreed to aim for a substantial expansion of bilateral trade by 2030. Avenues for agricultural cooperation are also being explored. India shares with Australia and New Zealand a concern about maintaining stability and predictability in the Indo-Pacific. Supply-chain diversification, energy security, and access to critical minerals and emerging technology are key priorities for India, which is trying to protect its strategic autonomy in a world of great volatility. The Modi government has been trying to achieve this objective through building a network of partnerships. These visits fit into that pattern. India's challenge is in keeping itself steady in an era of global turmoil, and untangled from rivalries that can do it no good. Mr. Modi's visits build on this awareness.

Steady in Turbulence: India Must Build Partnerships in This Age of Global Turmoil

- **The Visits**

- PM Modi's recent visits to Australia and New Zealand marked a shift from largely economic/people-centric ties toward a stronger strategic dimension, consolidating India's position across the Indo-Pacific

- **Australia Outcomes**

- A new Joint Declaration on Defence and Security Cooperation was adopted, enhancing interoperability and expanding military exercises; Australia also agreed to allow uranium exports for India's civilian nuclear programme

- **New Zealand Outcomes**

- India-New Zealand relations were elevated to a formal strategic partnership with a four-year cooperation roadmap, including maritime cooperation and mutual logistics support between defence forces

- **Strategic Framing**

- The visits reflect India's MAHASAGAR vision and Act East Policy, aiming to strengthen the "southern arc" of the Indo-Pacific amid supply-chain disruption and geopolitical realignment

Steady in Turbulence: India Must Build Partnerships in This Age of Global Turmoil

- **What Is the Indo-Pacific Construct?**

- A geopolitical framing treating the Indian and Pacific Oceans as a single strategic theatre, central to countering China's rising assertiveness and ensuring freedom of navigation

- **India's Act East Policy**

- Launched in 2014, evolving from the 1990s "Look East Policy", it aims to deepen India's economic, strategic and cultural engagement with Southeast Asian and Pacific nations

- **What Is MAHASAGAR?**

- Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions a newer articulation of India's regional vision, extending the earlier SAGAR doctrine focused on the Indian Ocean

- **Strategic Autonomy**

- India's foreign policy principle of engaging multiple powers without becoming formally allied to any one bloc, preserving independent decision-making in foreign and security policy

Tourism Can Unlock India's Journey to a New Milestone

Tourism can unlock India's journey to a new milestone



PUNEET CHHATWAL

INDIAN TOURISM and hospitality sector is emerging as one of the key contributors to the nation's economic growth every year with a GDP share of about 7 percent. It is a catalyst for employment generation with every direct job creating multiple indirect jobs, accounting for over 1 percent of total jobs in India. In addition, it drives entrepreneurship, infrastructure development and foreign exchange earnings, and positions India's soft power on the global stage.

As India aspires to become one of the world's leading tourism economies, the opportunity lies beyond attracting visitors to unlocking the economic value of its natural, cultural and spiritual assets. India's tourism wealth is a strategic asset capable of propelling broad-based economic growth.

India's hospitality sector has moved decisively beyond post-pandemic recovery. Occupancy levels across major markets have consistently remained strong, average room rates have surpassed pre-pandemic levels and demand continues to be buoyant. This has enhanced investor confidence and strengthened the industry's ability to invest in capacity building, innovation and guest experiences. The sector's growing attractiveness is reflected in rising participation from institutional funds, family offices, listed hotel companies and developers. While institutional investment has grown, it remains below the levels seen in more mature hospitality markets. This presents a significant opportunity.

A defining characteristic of India's current tourism growth cycle is the emergence of a more distributed demand landscape. For decades, much of the hospitality industry's performance was concentrated in a handful of metropolitan cities and established destinations. Today, growth is increasingly driven by Tier-II and Tier-III cities, creating a more diversified and resilient ecosystem.

Infrastructure development is reinforcing this transformation. The expansion of regional airports, improvements in road networks and the development of economic and industrial corridors are fundamentally reshaping tourism flows. Every new airport, highway, convenient facility or transport link has the potential to unlock new destinations, stimulate local investment, and create hospitality demand.

Airport-centric development is emerging as a significant driver of hotel growth, supported by business travel, transit stays, meetings, incentives, conferences and exhibitions. Tourism and infrastructure are becoming increasingly interdependent, each amplifying the impact of the other. Realising the potential of tourism requires greater alignment between infrastructure, investment, policy and destination development. Hospitality development should therefore be integrated into broader economic planning, ensuring that investments in airports, highways and urban infrastructure are complemented by destination readiness, accommodation capacity and visitor experiences. Policy support will play a critical role in unlocking the \$2-trillion travel and tourism opportunity.

The Federation of Associations in Indian Tourism & Hospitality (FATIH), the apex body representing India's tourism and hospitality sector, has called for a time-bound action agenda to position India as a global tourism powerhouse. Key priorities include granting industry status to tourism across all states, which will improve access to capital and reduce financing costs. The government should fast-track the development of 50 tourism destinations on mission mode, supported by clear implementation timelines. Simultaneously, India needs a dedicated global tourism promotion campaign under a streamlined Bharat mission, alongside sustained funding. A more liberal visa regime, including expedited e-visa access and simplified entry procedures, can significantly boost inbound tourism. Investment in tourism infrastructure ranging from last-mile connectivity to world-class amenities and digital infrastructure will further elevate visitor experience. Rationing taxation to align with global benchmarks and creating a single-window clearance will encourage greater private sector participation.

As India charts its path toward becoming a leading tourism destination, the challenge is no longer proving the sector's potential, it is harnessing it at scale. The multiplier effect of tourism ensures that economic benefits extend well beyond hotels and travel companies, reaching communities across urban and rural India. Few sectors have the ability to create such broad-based prosperity while simultaneously showcasing a nation's heritage, diversity and identity. That is the true essence of ' Incredible India, Irresistible Economics' — recognising tourism as a powerful pathway to national growth, prosperity and global influence.

The writer is chairman, Federation of Associations in Indian Tourism and Hospitality



tourism, tourism

Tourism Can Unlock India's Journey to a New Milestone

- **Economic Significance**

- India's tourism and hospitality sector contributes about **7% of GDP and accounts for over 9% of total employment** in India, generating multiple indirect jobs for every direct job created

- **Post-Pandemic Recovery**

- The hospitality sector has moved decisively beyond pandemic-era disruption, with occupancy levels and average room rates surpassing pre-pandemic levels and demand continuing to grow

- **Shifting Growth Pattern**

- **Tourism growth is increasingly driven by Tier-II and Tier-III cities** rather than being concentrated in a handful of metropolitan destinations, creating a more diversified tourism ecosystem

- **Infrastructure as a Catalyst**

- Expansion of regional airports, road networks and industrial corridors is reshaping tourism flows; airport-centric development is emerging as a significant driver of hotel growth and business travel

- **Policy Recommendations**

- FAITH calls for granting industry status to tourism nationwide, fast-tracking 50 mission-mode destinations, a liberalised e-visa regime, and a single-window clearance mechanism for private participation

Tourism Can Unlock India's Journey to a New Milestone

- **What Is "Industry Status" for Tourism?**

- A formal government classification making tourism businesses eligible for benefits available to other industries priority-sector lending, tax incentives, easier institutional finance something tourism in most states currently lacks

- **MICE Tourism**

- Meetings, Incentives, Conferences and Exhibitions a high-value segment of business tourism generating significant revenue through corporate travel and events, distinct from leisure tourism

- **Tourism's Multiplier Effect**

- Tourism spending generates indirect and induced economic activity across transport, retail, food services and construction, making its total economic impact larger than direct tourism jobs alone suggest

- **India's Global Tourism Positioning**

- Despite significant natural, cultural and heritage assets, India's global tourism competitiveness has historically lagged behind smaller countries with more developed infrastructure and simpler entry processes

Thank You